suspects, each of whom Poirot deems to have just cause to kill him).[54] And in his acclaimed biography of Nikita Khrushchev, William Taubman suggests that the Soviet premier saw the deployment as ‘a cure-all’ for a range of problems, albeit ‘a cure-all that cured nothing’.[55]

By 1998 Raymond Garthoff revised his assessment. The Soviet decision ‘had two principal motivations and purposes’: firstly, ‘to contribute to redressing the global strategic inferiority of the Soviet Union’, and secondly, ‘to deter an anticipated US attack on Cuba.’[56] However, in 2006 Fursenko and Naftali’s new study, *Khrushchev’s Cold War,* provided fresh understanding of the problems with the new generation of Soviet ICBMs, the R-9 [NATO designation SS-8] and the R-16 [NATO designation SS-7].[57] The R-16 especially was proving a considerable disappointment. The new generation of soon-to-be deployed US Minuteman ICBMs were solid-fuelled missiles that could be held at a readiness state of fifteen minutes. Deployed in silos, they represented a credible retaliatory capability. An even more credible second-strike missile was provided by the solid-fuelled Polaris SLBM that entered service in 1960.

The R-16 was a liquid-fuelled missile that needed hours to fuel. Once fuelled, it needed to be fired immediately or drained of its corrosive fuel. The US first-generation ICBMs and IRBMs were also liquid-fuelled but did not suffer the same problems. Without effective early warning, and command and control systems, Soviet ICBMs were, in any case, incapable of launching under warning or launching under attack. They might be credible as first-strike weapons, but as such presented an invitation to US pre-emption (once US intelligence knew where they were). The bad news was conveyed to Khrushchev by the chief of his rocket forces in February 1962, who told him, ‘Before we managed to move the R-16 and lift it into place, nothing would be left of us.’[58] It is difficult to assess how much the news informed Khrushchev’s thinking, but telling the Presidium that missiles in Cuba were necessary to defend a revolutionary ally was a different proposition than telling them it was necessary to mitigate Soviet strategic vulnerability (especially after his repeated boasts about Soviet superiority).